Religious Policy

Harsha was the worshipper of Shiva in the beginning, but he embraced Buddhism under the influence of his sister Rajyashri and the Buddhist monk and traveller Hiuen Tsang. He belonged to Mahayana school of thought. Harsha treated Vedic scholars and Buddhist monks alike and distributed charities equally to them. He was the last Buddhist sovereign in India. As a pious Buddhist, Harsha stopped the killing of animals for food.

Hiuen Tsang, the 'prince of pilgrims', visited India during Harsha's reign. His *Si-Yu-Ki* provides detailed information about the social, economic, religious and cultural conditions of India during Harsha's time. Hiuen Tsang tells us how Harsha, though a Buddhist, went to participate in the great *kumbhamela* held at Prayag.



Hiuen Tsang

He was noted for his policy of religious toleration and used to worship the images of Buddha, Shiva and Sun simultaneously. He summoned two Buddhist assemblies, one at Kanauj and another at Prayag.

The assembly at Kanauj was attended by 20 kings. A large number of Buddhist, Jain and Vedic scholars attended the assembly. A golden statue of Buddha was consecrated in a monastery and a small statue of Buddha (three feet) was carried in a procession.

In the assembly at Prayag, Harsha distributed his wealth among the Buddhists, Vedic scholars and poor people. Harsha offered fabulous gifts to the Buddhist monks on all the four days of the assembly.

Art and Literature

Harsha, himself a poet and dramatist, gathered around him a best of poets and artists. Harsha's popular works are *Ratnavali*, *Nagananda* and *Priyadharshika.* His royal court was adorned by Banabhatta, Mayura, Hardatta and Jayasena.

Temples and monasteries functioned as centres of learning. Kanauj became a famous city. Harsha constructed a large number of viharas, monasteries and stupas on the bank of the Ganges. The Nalanda University, a university and monastery combined, was said to have had 10,000 students and monks in residence, when Hiuen Tsang visited the university.

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